



Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-  
universality

Divine  
control

Justice

# Proportion- ality

# Continuity

Universalism certainly seems hard to reconcile with the teachings of most main monotheistic sects. Going further would mean verging into theology rather than philosophy, so I'll leave the discussion of this way out of the problem here, and turn to our next response.

Is it really true that there is no way to divide people into two groups, so that no one in one group is similar in their relevant properties to anyone in the other group?

This would seem to depend on what the relevant properties are. If God decided who goes to heaven and hell based on height, then Continuity would be plainly true. But of course height is not a relevant property.

What might the relevant properties be?

Let's consider some candidates.



the  
paradox of  
heaven and  
hell



replies to the  
paradox

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not worth  
living

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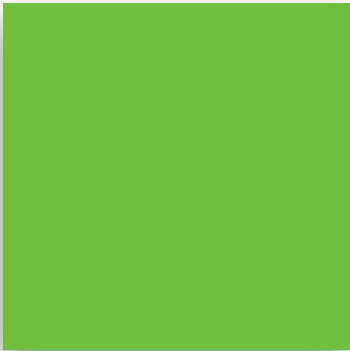
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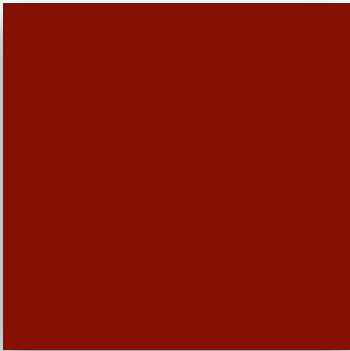














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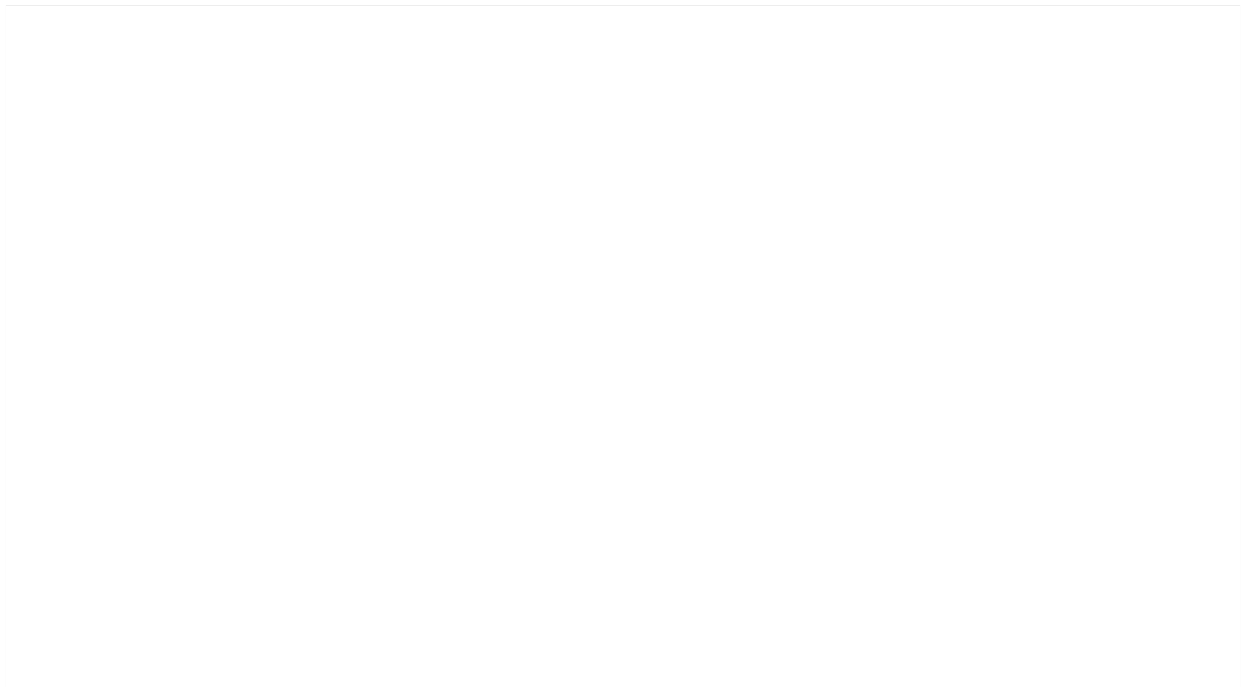
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The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:



but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

eternity!

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

into external punishment, but the rights into

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

perfectly good Good?

many of the major monotheistic religions compatible with the existence of a



both the just and the unjust," will proceed

this glory, and all the angels with him.

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

and the wild sheep are then from another

but the rights are all in it.

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

they will go away into eternal punishment,

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?

































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evil & lives  
not worth  
living



Badness

Divine  
control

Justice



Continuity

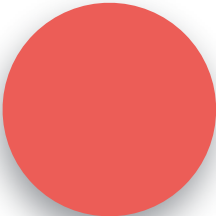
It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.





replies to the  
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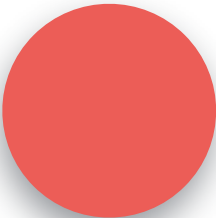








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